

Practice Paper 4 — Answer Scheme

Paper 2 — Comprehension

Sections B & C

Note to teachers and students

- Marks are awarded for **meaning**, not for exact words. Where a quotation is required, it has been indicated in inverted commas.
- Where the question asks for **own words**, a candidate who lifts directly from the text receives **zero** for that mark unless the lifted phrase is unavoidable.
- For language and tone questions, accept any reasonable alternative that clearly fits the textual evidence.

Section B — Text 3 Answer Scheme [20 marks]

Q1. [2] — Attitude before the shift

Award **1 mark** for identifying her **good intentions** / her belief that being kind would be easy; **1 mark** for explaining that her kindness was **untested** / **theoretical** and had not yet been challenged by real difficulty.

Sample answer: The phrase suggests that the narrator's kindness was **effortless and confident**, but only because her commitment to helping others had **not yet been put under any real strain**; she assumed it would come naturally.

Q2. [2] — Mrs Tan's behaviour

1 mark — Mrs Tan is **sceptical** / **unconvinced** that the volunteer truly understands what she is in for.

1 mark — The fact that she does **not smile** and questions whether the volunteer is “sure” suggests she has seen **many enthusiastic newcomers** who do not last, and is **quietly testing** the narrator's resolve.

Q3. [2] — “Not so much frightened as resigned”

1 mark — The dog is **past being afraid** — fear implies hope of escape.

1 mark — He has **given up** / **accepted** his situation; he expects bad things to happen and no longer expects to be saved.

Q4. [2] — “The clean T-shirt suddenly felt absurd”

1 mark — She realises that her **outward appearance of preparedness** is meaningless in the face of the dog's real suffering.

1 mark — It reveals a **loss of confidence** / **embarrassment** at her own naivety; what felt appropriate twenty minutes earlier now feels **out of place** and **ridiculous**.

Q5. [2] — “The shape one made in the air”

1 mark — A frightened dog cannot understand words but responds to **the volunteer’s body language / posture and movement**.

1 mark — The dog watches her **physical presence** to judge whether it **looks dangerous** or **safe** — so she must control how she occupies space, not what she says.

Q6. [3] — Speed and silence of the dog (language question)

1 mark for identifying the **technique** (short sentences / repetition / contrast between long stillness and instant movement / sentence structure mimicking suddenness); **1 mark each** for **two** clearly quoted and explained details (max 2).

Accept any two of:

- “without any sound at all” — the explicit denial of sound emphasises **total silence**.
- “he was beside the chicken, and then the chicken was gone, and then he was back in his corner” — the **rapid listing** with “and then... and then” mimics how **fast** the action happened.
- “I had not seen him move” — the narrator’s own **failure to perceive the motion** conveys how quick it was.
- “less than two seconds” — **precise, short measurement** underlines the speed.
- “smaller, somehow, than before” — even after moving, his return is silent and shrinking.

Each detail must be **quoted** and **explained**; mere lifting without explanation = ½ mark.

Q7. [2] — Admission of resentment

1 mark — She is **honest / self-aware** enough to admit an **unflattering feeling** rather than pretend to be perfectly patient.

1 mark — It shows she is **human / imperfect**; her kindness is **real** but **has limits**, and she is willing to acknowledge those limits.

Q8. [1] — “Properly” between two commas

1 mark: The commas **isolate and emphasise** the word **properly**, drawing the reader’s attention to it. They suggest she had **technically** believed the leaflet but had not taken it **seriously** or **to heart** — the punctuation underlines her self-criticism.

Q9. [2] — Mrs Tan’s remark

1 mark — The fact that the dog **does not run away / allows the volunteer to remain near him** is itself a major achievement, given how frightened he is.

1 mark — **Real progress** in earning a frightened animal’s trust is not the dog approaching, but the dog **tolerating presence** — patience and stillness are the work, not affection.

Q10. [1] — Change in understanding the dog

1 mark: She no longer sees the bared tooth as **aggression** but as **desperation / a plea**; she now understands that his behaviour comes from **fear**, not malice, and that **she** is the cause of his distress.

Q11. [1] — Tone of the final sentence

1 mark — Any **one** of: **reflective, humbled, thoughtful, changed, quietly transformed.**
(Reject: **sad, triumphant** — these miss the quiet, inward quality.)

Section C — Text 4 Answer Scheme [25 marks]

Q12. [2] — “Not natural environments for the human animal”

1 mark for understanding that humans are **biological creatures** with needs (light, quiet, space) that **cities do not naturally provide**.

1 mark for understanding the writer’s view: cities are **artificial** and at odds with how our bodies and minds **evolved** to live, so urban life **strains** us.

Q13. [2] — Two pieces of scientific evidence

1 mark each for any two of:

- A 2019 review of 140+ studies found **lower cortisol** (stress hormone) in those with regular green-space contact.
- University of Exeter researchers tracked 10,000 residents and found **measurable improvement in mental well-being** in those who moved to greener neighbourhoods.
- That benefit **persisted for at least three years**.
- Psychologists identify “**attention restoration**” as a mechanism.

Q14. [2] — “Attention restoration” (own words)

1 mark — The brain’s **focusing systems become tired** from the constant demands of urban life.

1 mark — Gentle, **undemanding natural stimuli** (leaves, water, birds) **allow these systems to recover / rest**, restoring the ability to concentrate.

Reject answers that lift “the soft, undemanding stimulus” without rewording.

Q15. [2] — “Connective tissue” in italics

1 mark — The italics **emphasise** the phrase as a **metaphor / figurative expression**, marking it out as the writer’s chosen image rather than a literal description.

1 mark — The effect is to **foreground** the idea: small, ordinary park encounters are what **binds the community together**, just as connective tissue binds the body — invisible but essential.

Q16. [2] — Other public spaces

1 mark — The word “**legitimately**” and the phrase “**without buying anything**” imply that most other public spaces (cafes, malls, shops) **require a purchase** in order to remain in them.

1 mark — The writer views most modern public space as **commercialised / transactional**, so a park is unusual in being **genuinely free and open** to anyone.

Q17. [2] — Effect of paragraph ending

1 mark — The writer shifts from **statistics** to **direct sensory appeal**, asking the reader to imagine standing on a hot, treeless street.

1 mark — This makes the injustice **vivid and felt**, not merely numerical; it turns an **abstract statistic** into a **visceral experience**, strengthening the argument emotionally.

Q18. [2] — “Almost worthless” lawn (own words)

1 mark — Although such a lawn is **green** and **visually pleasant**, the public **cannot enter** or use it.

1 mark — Because the health benefits of greenery require **contact, walking, sitting and meeting** in the space, a lawn that **excludes people** delivers **almost no real benefit**.

Q19. [2] — Why “pocket parks” are effective

1 mark each for any two of:

- They are **cheap** and **quick to build**.
- They are **small** and so **fit into existing neighbourhoods** without demolition.
- They are **close to people’s homes**, making them easy to use **on weekday evenings**, not only weekends.
- They deliver **disproportionate** psychological and social **gains** relative to their size.

Q20. [1] — Tone of “soil, drains and patient horticulture”

1 mark — **Matter-of-fact / dryly humorous / understated / deflating**. (Also accept: **pragmatic, unglamorous**. Reject: **sarcastic, bitter, dismissive**.)

Q21. [2] — “Most modest and most radical”

1 mark — The pairing is a **paradox / oxymoron**: **modest** (small, humble) and **radical** (drastic, transformative) seem to contradict each other.

1 mark — The effect is to surprise the reader and emphasise that **a tiny, ordinary action** — planting one tree — can in fact produce **deep and far-reaching change** in a community’s health and equality.

Q22. Summary [13 marks total: 6 content + 7 style]

Content points (½ mark each, max 6 marks). Eight available content points; candidates should aim for all 8.

Benefits of urban green spaces (Paragraphs 2–3, 5–6):

1. They **lower stress hormones** (cortisol) and improve mental well-being for years.
2. They allow the brain’s **focus systems to rest** through gentle natural stimuli (“attention restoration”).
3. They **encourage walking, sitting and physical activity**.
4. They are **free, open public spaces** where strangers can meet without spending money — building neighbourhood ties.
5. Well-designed **pocket parks** deliver large gains relative to their small size, especially when close to homes.

Obstacles to providing them equitably (Paragraphs 4–6):

6. Access is **deeply unequal** — wealthy districts have far more green space than poorer ones.
7. **Poor design** (e.g. closed, ornamental lawns) wastes space and delivers little benefit.
8. The work is **slow, unglamorous and technical** (soil, drainage, horticulture), making it easy for planners to neglect.

Sample full-marks summary (78 words):

Urban green spaces benefit city dwellers by lowering stress, restoring concentration, and inviting people to walk and socialise. They function as free, open meeting places where neighbours casually mix, knitting communities together. Small, well-placed pocket parks deliver outsized gains when situated close to homes. Yet such benefits are unevenly distributed: richer districts enjoy far more greenery than poorer ones, poor design wastes potential, and the patient horticultural work involved is unglamorous and easily overlooked by planners.

Length count: 78 words from “Urban” onwards.

— END OF ANSWER SCHEME —